

The Origins of Gershwin's* *Summertime*
(from the Dramatic Folk Opera *Porgy and Bess*)

When I first heard the song called *Summertime*, Jascha Heifitz (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KvfsTGny2JI>) was playing it on a reissued RCA Red Seal CD recording. In 8th grade, I never knew it was part of an entire dramatic folk opera called *Porgy & Bess*. When I went back to my local library, I was anxious to look up who precisely composed the *Summertime* aria from the opera/American musical, *Porgy & Bess*.

The work was credited to the Jewish American composer George Gershwin. It also had lyrics to its melody, based upon a generic antebellum Southern Black dialect of former Black American slaves. But after reading more about Gershwin's bio and rise to stardom, I kept thinking to myself, how did a Brooklyn Jew nail such authentic Southern Negro lyrics by just spending a few months in the American South for inspiration?!?

Well, the answer did not come until I took this class and heard excerpts of William Grant Still's *Afro-American Symphony*. Intonations from that were immediately reminiscent of excerpts from Gershwin's *Rhapsody in Blue*—allegedly written by George himself in just three weeks! As a bunch of "catchy melodies strung together by the barest of musical links" (Britannica: <https://www.britannica.com/biography/George-Gershwin>.) it became clear where much of George Gershwin's music came from.

George Gershwin was a talented jazz pianist who grew up as a street performer in NYC's Tin Pan Alley—after dropping out of school at age 15. William Grant Still was a premedical student at Wilberforce University but then switched to music to study at Oberlin College's Conservatory of Music and later the New England Conservatory of Music under George Whitefield Chadwick and afterward Edgard Varese. So, who was the better-trained music theorist capable of unique musical (and orchestral) composition? William Grant Still.

Where's the proof? I am no musicologist, but an amateur listener can hear beyond coincidental music similarities from Gershwin's *Summertime* in this modern performance of Still's *Summerland* (Madeline Adkins, violin; Jason Hardink, piano; Grand Teton Music Festival: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hE8ZrZbu5_8):

1:59-2:07: the tail end of Gershwin's *Summertime*--leading melodic hook found in Still's *Summerland*

3:04-3:11: the tail end of Gershwin's *Summertime*—leading harmonic hook found in Still's *Summerland*

NB: I am sure if I had more time and access to both Gershwin's and Still's sheet music, more examples of *near-verbatim* appropriation or outright plagiarism from William Grant Still's musical work would become immediately apparent.

In 2011, Still's daughter, Judith Anne Still, came out in a public blog to call for a boycott of Gershwin's music based on her plagiarism claim on behalf of her late father (<https://africlassical.blogspot.com/2011/06/judith-anne-still-i-would-like-to-start.html>). Shameless was the cultural appropriation and outright plagiarism from Black jazz artists of the period, the great composer Edgard Varese later reflected:

In 1928, when he was asked about jazz, [Varese] said it was not representative of America but instead was "a negro product, exploited by the Jews. All of its composers here are Jews," meaning Gruenberg and Boulanger as students, including Copland and Blitzstein (Crunden 42-3).

Of course, let's not forget the creator of the aria and opera in its modern form: Claudio Monteverdi. He first debuted it in his performance of *L'Orfeo* (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jUep3sqe35o>) for the Duke of Mantua in 1607 (Wright 90-91). *L'Orfeo* was the first instance of a musical score accompanied by a written script (libretto) to tell a story via:

a.) An *aria*: like a character's aside in Shakespearean plays, but set to melodic verse

b.) A *recitative*: less melodic and more character-read dialogue on stage

c.) A *ritornello*: a central musical theme (a la Beethoven's Symphony No. 5—"Fate's Doorknock" theme; a.k.a., a *leitmotif* in Wagnerian Opera).

NB: The complete plot summary is recounted in Professor Pratt's class notes and the Listening to Music--8th edition recommended textbook by Craig Wright.

In conclusion, I guess if it sounds too great or too fantastic to be true, it probably was a lie, to begin with? Moreover, it must have made Mr. Still's stomach turn every time *Porgy & Bess* and other ghostwritten/plagiarized works of his received recognition from the mainstream press and luminaries of the time, even up to his death. To create a work of art and not be able to take any credit for it is like birthing a King without ever seeing or talking to the child. *Porgy* may have been Still's proverbial baby all along. Money aside, I believe musicologists should formally vindicate William Grant Still. Moreover, historians should also attach an asterisk symbol ("*") to George Gershwin's name in all existing credits of the *Porgy & Bess* score and musical showbill. The man was a fraud and got far more credit than he deserved, all at the expense of the work's actual creator(s) (maybe more than just William Grant Still, alone).

(Word Count: 785)

Works Cited

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